

When I talk to athletes, whether they are cricketers, footballers, runners, weightlifters or swimmers, the first question they ask is almost always about protein.

Everyone wants to know how many scoops of powder to take, how much chicken to eat, or whether they need another shake after training.

Protein has become the star of sports nutrition conversations. But in this loud talk about protein, one big factor is often ignored: calories.

Take this for example: a 65–70 kilo fighter who trains three times a day may need around 3,800 calories daily. If 20 per cent of that is protein, it works out to about 200 grams. That already crosses the recommended two grams per kilo of body weight. Yet many athletes still keep asking if they need more supplements.

The real question should be: are they eating enough total calories to match their training load?

Calories are the energy the body runs on. Without enough fuel, recovery slows, strength does not improve, and performance suffers.

If calorie intake is too low, even the protein that's eaten may get burned for energy instead of repairing muscles.

That is why any good sports nutrition plan begins with calories first, not protein.

To know calorie needs, we begin with something called Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR). This is the energy the body needs at rest for basic functions such as breathing, circulation and digestion.

On top of that, we add the energy cost of training and daily activity. This gives us the Total Energy Expenditure (TEE). Only when we know this number can we plan how much an athlete must eat every day.

Measuring energy needs

There are simple equations that give an estimate of BMR using age, weight and height. But serious athletes need more than guesswork. Advanced methods like indirect calorimetry measure oxygen and carbon dioxide while breathing to give accurate energy use.

Fitness trackers and smart wearables can track activity and help estimate calorie burn during training. Even something as basic as daily weighing, combined with a food diary, can show whether an athlete is under-eating or over-eating.

Each athlete is different. Genetics, training intensity and even mental stress change energy needs. That is why copy-pasting numbers from the internet or from another athlete does not work.

Getting this wrong can mean entering a match, a race or a training session tired and flat. Getting it right can mean stepping onto the field, court or track fully charged and ready.

The protein paradox

Once calories are sorted, protein comes next. Here is the paradox. In normal training, most athletes already eat more than enough protein from their regular diet. Eggs, chicken, fish, *daal*, *paneer* and milk add up quickly. When you are eating 3,800 calories, it is very easy to touch or cross 200 grams of protein without supplements. In such cases, powders are often unnecessary.

But during weight cuts, the story changes. When an athlete must drop weight before competition, calories from carbohydrates and fats are reduced. Protein intake is kept high to protect muscle. This phase is tricky. Reduce calories too much and energy drops. Cut protein and muscle is lost. The balance lies in dropping carbs and fats carefully while holding protein steady. This

helps the athlete reach the right weight without losing strength.

Why a nutritionist is essential

This is why every serious athlete should work with a sports nutritionist. Nutrition is not about one fixed rule. It has to change with the training phase, competition schedule and the body's response. A nutritionist does not just look at protein but builds the whole equation: total calories, macronutrient split, hydration and recovery.

Think of it like game strategy. A cricket team does not play T20 the same way as in a Test match. A football team defends differently when leading and attacks differently when chasing. Nutrition is the same. In heavy training phases, the plan is to eat more calories for recovery. In weight-cut phases, the plan is to reduce calories but still protect muscle. Both depend on knowing the metabolism of the athlete.

So, it is time athletes in India asked better questions. Protein is important, but it is not the magic solution. Calories come first. Without meeting calorie needs, protein cannot do its job. The real foundation is energy balance. Once that is set, protein, carbohydrates and fats fall into place. So the next time you think about your diet, do not just ask — "Am I getting enough protein?" Also ask — "Am I eating enough calories for my training?" That one shift in mindset can change performance, recovery and even career longevity.

In sport, every small edge matters. Getting nutrition right is not about more powders or expensive supplements. It is understanding the body, measuring needs, and building a plan. As I remind every athlete I work with, victory does not start only on the pitch, court or track. It starts at the dining table, with calories first, protein second, and balance always.